

"On the Verge"

"From Coward to Courageous!"

Sunday, October 24th, 2004, - Sermon Book 10

AM Service

Δ denotes prologue slide

Σ denotes drama, audio or video cue

Joshua 1:9 NKJV

Email Humor: "NEVER ENOUGH"

"The story is told of two old friends who bumped into one another on the street one day. One of them looked forlorn, almost on the verge of tears. His friend asked, "What has the world done to you, my old friend?" The sad fellow said, "Let me tell you. Three weeks ago, an uncle died and left me forty thousand dollars." "That's a lot of money." "But, two weeks ago, a cousin I never even knew died, and left me eighty-five thousand free and clear." "Sounds like you've been blessed...." "You don't understand!" he interrupted. "Last week my great-aunt passed away. I inherited almost a quarter of a million." Now he was really confused. "Then, why do you look so glum?" "This week... nothing!"

Joshua 1:9 NKJV

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and of good courage; do not be afraid, nor be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

Israel

- On the verge of possessing their promised land...
- They had been waiting in the wilderness 40 years...
 - Enduring heat...
 - Enduring great trials...
 - Enduring the wait...
- They had been waiting in Egypt for over 400 years to come home...

- Carrying the bones of their ancestor Jacob... they leave in a miraculous way...
- Everyone of us are a miracle of His blessing – leaving a life of sin...

How many of you are living **ON THE VERGE**... of something great happening...

Tonight, that is the title of my message:

Δ “On the Verge!”

Is there anything God has told you to do... and you have been waiting, You have been **“ON THE VERGE”** but now is the time to go in and possess the land?

How many of you have ever been on the verge?

Too many times people are on the verge of something bad happening...

David in Psalm 38 sounds like He’s on the verge of a Nervous Breakdown...

Psalms 38:17 NLT

“I am on the verge of collapse, facing constant pain.”

God doesn’t want you to have a breakdown...

He wants you to have a breakthrough...

He doesn’t want you to collapse... under the load

He wants you to conquer...

He wants to carry you...

He wants to help you...

On the other hand...

The Disciples were on the verge of sinking because of the blessing...

Luke 5:7NLT

"A shout for help brought their partners in the other boat, and soon both boats were filled with fish and on the verge of sinking."

All of a sudden both boats were filled with fish and on the verge... of sinking... So much blessing... they could not contain it all...

What are you "ON THE VERGE" of?

A Collapse?

A Blessing?

"Ravi Zacharias tells the amazing story of a young Christian in Vietnam. He writes, "I was ministering in Vietnam in 1971, and one of my interpreters was Hien Pham, an energetic young Christian. He had worked as a translator with the American forces, and was of immense help both to them and to missionaries such as myself. Hien and I traveled the length of the country and became very close friends before I returned home. We did not know if our paths would ever cross again. Seventeen years later, I received a telephone call. 'Brother Ravi?' the man asked. Immediately I recognized Hien's voice, and he soon told me his story. Shortly after Vietnam fell, Hien was imprisoned on accusations of helping the Americans. His jailers tried to indoctrinate him against democratic ideals and the Christian faith. He was restricted to communist propaganda in French or Vietnamese, and the daily deluge of Marx and Engels began to take its toll. 'Maybe,' he thought, 'I have been lied to. Maybe God does not exist. Maybe the West has deceived me.'

So Hien determined that when he awakened the next day, he would not pray anymore or think of his faith.

The next morning, he was assigned the dreaded chore of cleaning the prison latrines. As he cleaned out a tin can overflowing with toilet paper, his eye caught what seemed to be English printed on one piece of paper. He hurriedly grabbed it, washed it, and after his roommates had retired that night, he retrieved the paper and read the words, 'Romans, Chapter 8.'

Trembling, he began to read, Δ 'And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love Him. . . for I am convinced that nothing shall be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord.'

Hien wept. He knew His Bible, and knew that there was not a more relevant passage for one on the verge of surrender. He cried out to God, asking forgiveness, for this was to have been the first day that he would not pray. . . . After finding the Scripture, Hien asked the commander if he could clean the latrines regularly, because he discovered that some official was using a Bible as toilet paper. Each day Hien picked up a portion of Scripture, cleaned it off, and added it to his collection of nightly reading. . . . What his tormentors were using for refuse — the Scriptures — could not be more treasured to Hien." Eventually he was released from prison and fled to Thailand. Today he is a businessman in the United States, a radiant Christian and a living testimony to the power of God's Word and its transforming power.

Hien was on the verge of giving up...

But God was on the verge of a blessing...

Proverbs 28:1

"The wicked run away when no one is chasing them, but the godly are as bold as lions."

Through prayer the psalmist has a breakthrough...

Fear – or – Faith...

Psalms 34:4

"I prayed to the Lord, and He answered me, freeing me from all my fears."

Are you on the verge of faith?

Or the verge of fear?

Fear to respond...

Fear to hear...

Fear to accept... What He is telling you to do...

Δ Psalms 27:1-3

"The Lord is my light and my salvation – so why should I be afraid? The Lord protects me from danger – so why should I tremble? When evil people come to destroy me, when my enemies and foes attack me, they will stumble and fall. Though a mighty army surrounds me, my heart will know no fear. Even if they attack me, I remain confident."

Philippians 1:28

"Don't be intimidated by your enemies. This will be a sign to them that they are going to be destroyed, but that you are going to be saved, even by God Himself."

Confidence in the Lord is a sign to Satan – (Satan) is going to be destroyed...

Daniel 3:16-18

“Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego replied, ‘O Nebuchadnezzar, we do not need to defend ourselves before you. If we are thrown into the blazing furnace, the God whom we serve is able to save us. He will rescue us from your power, Your Majesty. But even if he doesn’t, Your Majesty can be sure that we will never serve your gods or worship the gold statue you have set up.’”

- **He saying,**

- Quitting is not an option...
- Giving in is not an option...
- Turning back is not an option...

It wasn’t too many days before the children of Israel were ready to go back to Egypt... But who was going to open the Red Sea? Who would take them back across?

Are you on the verge of a Collapse or a Blessing?

- **Abel** was on the verge of **a blessing** when he prepared an more excellent offering...

- **Enoch** was on the verge of **a blessing** when he walked with God...

- **Noah** was on the verge of **a blessing** when “...being warned of God of things not seen as yet, moved with fear, prepared an ark to the saving of his house; by the which he condemned the world, and became heir of the righteousness which is by faith.”

- **Abraham** was on the verge of **a blessing** when he offered up Isaac as a sacrifice... “he looked for a city which hath foundations, whose builder and maker is God.”

- **Sarah** was on the verge of **a blessing** "...because she judged him faithful who had promised."
- **Isaac** was on the verge of **a blessing** "...when he blessed Jacob and Esau concerning things to come."
- **Joseph** was on the verge of **a blessing** when he revealed who he was to his brothers who had sold him into slavery...
- **Moses** was on the verge of **a blessing** when he followed the command of the Lord to go back to Egypt and lead God's people from bondage...
- **Moses** was on the verge of a blessing at the Red Sea Crossing...
- **Rahab** was on the verge of a blessing when "...when she had received the spies with peace."
- **Joshua** was on the verge of a blessing when he commanded the people to shout...
- **Samson** was on the verge **a blessing** when he picked up a donkey's jaw bone to fight a battle...
- **Gideon** was on the verge of a blessing – in the dark, holding a pitcher, torch and a trumpet...
- **Ruth** was on the verge of **a blessing** when she found Boaz' Field...
- **Jesse** was on the verge of **a blessing** when Samuel showed up at his house...
- **David** was on the verge of **a blessing** when he chose 5 smooth stones and a sling to fight a giant...
- **Elijah** was on the verge of a blessing when he poured water on the sacrifice...
- **Elisha** was on the verge of a blessing when he burned his plow and killed his oxen...
- **Simon Peter** was on the verge of **a blessing** when he asked the Lord, "if that is you bid me to come to you on the water?"

• **Paul** was on the verge of **a blessing** when he started praising God in a prison... at the midnight hour...

[Δ Isaiah 51:12](#)

"I, even I, am the one who comforts you. So why are you afraid of mere humans, who wither like the grass and disappear?"

Are you on the verge of a blessing?

- Has God been pin pointing something in your life?
- Have you been on the verge of giving in to God?
- Have you been on the verge of saying yes?
- Have you been on the verge of getting involved?
- Tonight is your night to say yes...

Get ready God is wanting to bless you!

[Δ I Corinthians 16:13](#)

"Be on guard. Stand true to what you believe. Be courageous. Be strong."

In the closing days of World War II, Allied bombings of the munitions factories around Essen, Germany, became more and more frequent and fierce. When the air raid sirens sounded, armed guards would rush to bomb shelters, leaving the slave laborers (often Jewish and female) to huddle in the rubble and take their own chances.

On March 11, 1945, at the height of an endless bombardment, Elizabeth Roth and five companions decided to make their escape. They crept to the barbed wire surrounding the factory where they worked, crawled through a gap, and made their way across an empty field to a hill overlooking the town where they hoped to find a hiding place.

There, on the verge of freedom, one of the girls lost her nerve. Quietly, she turned back, re-crossed the field, crawled back through the wire, and returned to the wreckage of the factory. The next day, along with five hundred other female workers, she was loaded onto a train and sent to Buchenwald and the gas chambers.

In recounting this story, William Manchester remarks, “It is a common phenomenon among escapees; the known, however ghastly, seems preferable to the unknown.”

Who would do such a thing?” you might ask. “What sane person would make such a tragic decision?” The answer is, **“We would.”**

Like Elizabeth and her friends, we know what it’s like to be imprisoned in a broken world. We’ve been there, living amid the wreckage, cowering under the consequences of our own failure and surrounded by our shattered lives, ruined relationships, and failed hopes.

Then, one day, Jesus comes and offers a means of escape. He takes us by the hand and leads us away from our old lives and habits. Over the wreckage and through the barriers and across the barren fields that separate us from God, Jesus guides us to a place

overlooking the possibility of shelter and deliverance. From a high hill, we're given a glimpse of life with God. We sit on the mountainside with Jesus, gazing at the Beatitudes and thinking what life could be if we walked His way. You can almost hear the wheels turning in the minds of fellow escapees. **"Is this possible? Can you teach an old dog like me new tricks? Maybe I should just go back to what I know."**

Tim Woodroof, Walk This Way: An Interactive Guide to Following Jesus, (Colorado Springs: NavPress, 1999), 195-196

On the verge of Freedom... but choosing death...

How many times have I seen people ready for God to do something great in their lives... and they stop and turn and go the other way...

They retreat when they should advance...

They give up... when they should give in and let God...

Are you on the verge?

Give God a chance tonight to work a miracle...